Friday the 13th: Why Do So Many People Fear This Day?

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Friday, November 13, 2026, is the third and last Friday the 13th of this year.

For most people, it is just the start of the weekend. But millions of people feel it is the unluckiest day of the year. Some people fear it so much that the fear has a long name: **paraskevidekatriaphobia**. No one knows for sure how the fear began. Professor Thomas Fernsler of the University of Delaware says 13 has a bad name because it comes right after 12. People see 12 as a full, tidy number. **Folklore** historian Donald Dossey says the fear may come from an old **Norse** myth. Twelve gods were at dinner when Loki, the god of **mischief**, tricked Hodr, the blind god of darkness, into killing Baldr, the god of joy and light. The Bible says Jesus was **crucified** on a Friday, soon after the Last Supper, which had 13 people. That day, American businesses may lose as much as $900 million, but a 2008 study in the Netherlands found fewer car accidents than on other Fridays.

Word Treasure

paraskevidekatriaphobia -- The long name for the fear of Friday the 13th.
Folklore -- Old stories and beliefs that people pass down over time.
Norse -- From the old peoples and stories of northern Europe.
mischief -- Playful trouble or naughty behavior.
crucified -- Put to death on a cross long ago.

Background you need

Friday the 13th is a day when the date 13 falls on a Friday, and many people think of it as an unlucky day.

Some people feel nervous because old stories and beliefs link the number 13 and Friday with bad luck.

The fear may come from old tales, like a Norse myth about a dinner of twelve gods that ended in trouble, and the Last Supper, which had thirteen people at the table.

Break it down

WHO: Millions of people who fear Friday the 13th, Professor Thomas Fernsler of the University of Delaware, folklore historian Donald Dossey, and the Norse gods Loki, Hodr, and Baldr.

WHAT: Millions of people feel Friday the 13th is the unluckiest day of the year, and American businesses may lose as much as $900 million on that day.

WHERE: The United States, where businesses may lose money on Friday the 13th, and the Netherlands, where a 2008 study counted car accidents.

WHY: No one knows for sure, but one idea is that 13 comes right after the tidy number 12, another is an old Norse myth about Loki tricking Hodr into killing Baldr, and the Bible says Jesus was crucified on a Friday soon after a Last Supper with 13 people.

Why it matters

Knowing where the fear of Friday the 13th comes from can help you decide for yourself whether to worry about the date or just enjoy the start of your weekend.

Test what you remember

1. What is special about Friday, November 13, 2026?

- (A) It is the third and last Friday the 13th of the year
- (B) It is the first Friday the 13th of the year
- (C) It is the only Friday the 13th of the year
- (D) It is the second Friday the 13th of the year

2. What is the long name for the fear of Friday the 13th?

- (A) Triskaidekaphobia
- (B) Claustrophobia
- (C) Paraskevidekatriaphobia
- (D) Arachnophobia

3. According to Professor Thomas Fernsler, why does the number 13 have a bad name?

- (A) Because it is an odd number
- (B) Because it is the number of people at the Last Supper
- (C) Because it is a lucky number in every country
- (D) Because it comes right after 12, which people see as a full, tidy number

4. In the old Norse myth told by Donald Dossey, who tricked Hodr into killing Baldr?

- (A) Loki, the god of mischief
- (B) Baldr
- (C) Donald Dossey
- (D) Hodr

5. According to the article, how many people were at the Last Supper?

- (A) 14 people
- (B) 12 people
- (C) 13 people
- (D) 11 people

6. What did a 2008 study in the Netherlands find about car accidents on Friday the 13th?

- (A) There were fewer car accidents than on other Fridays
- (B) There were no cars on the road at all
- (C) There were the same number of car accidents as on other Fridays
- (D) There were more car accidents than on other Fridays

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: C 3: D 4: A 5: C 6: A

Questions to think about

1. **Professor Thomas Fernsler: He says 13 has a bad name because it comes right after 12, which people see as a full, tidy number.**

2. **Donald Dossey: He says the fear may come from an old Norse myth in which Loki tricked Hodr into killing Baldr at a dinner of twelve gods.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):